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African urban life: the transformation of Ouagadougou

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CHAPTER VI Ethnic Interaction and the Role of Associations

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The numerical superiority of ethnic Mossi in contemporary Ouagadougou has served to mask the importance of the strangers in the early history and development of the town. As late as the end of World War II, the disparity between the two groups was not great. In 1945 there were more than 5,000 foreign Africans in a total African population of 17,800, only slightly less than one-third of the population. By 1962 the percentage of African strangers had declined to 23.5 per cent, amounting to only 13,578 in a total African urban population of 57,779 persons.¹ And, given the fact that only 5,078 are non-Voltaic strangers (such as Hausa, Malinke, and Yoruba) in contrast to 8,500 Voltaic strangers (Gourounsi, Boussansé, Bobo, Samogo, etc.), it is clear that the percentage of the traditional strangers in Ouagadougou has declined significantly. The number of traditional strangers in the 1964 Ouagadougou population of over 100,000 is unknown but, given the massive in-migration of rural Mossi, it is clear that the strangers are becoming demographically insignificant within the town.

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The people of Ouagadougou take pride in their hospitality to strangers, citing the historical presence of foreign traders and teachers in the town. Nevertheless, a gradient can be perceived in the way the contemporary Mossi majority views the strangers in its midst. As would be expected, the Ouagadougou Mossi hold the Mossi of the other kingdoms in high esteem, subject only to the normal chauvinism found in any local group. **The people of the town, especially the Mossi, subscribe to the almost universal belief that the Mossi from the northern region of Yatenga are touchy and haughty.** The

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townspeople attribute these same negative traits to the Gourmantche of the brother kingdom of Fada N'Gourma. There is general praise for the cleanliness of the houses and persons of the Bobo and Gourounsi women. The Mossi attitude toward the Gourounsi men is conditioned by the fact that the ¹⁹⁶ Mossi were still expanding and absorbing the Gourounsi when the French arrived. Mossi often jokingly refer to the Gourounsi as their *ligidi* (meaning money), implying their status as individuals to be sold as slaves. The joking relationship between Mogho and Samogho is more nearly symmetrical. Both groups declare that their two ancestors quarreled over the bones of a dog, and this quarrel still continues. However, there are no rituals or ceremonies in which these joking relationships are dramatized.

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¹"Recensement Démographique...", pp. 10, 13.

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